

C01 · KNOWING

The Stranger Across From Me

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Stranger Across From Me

For a few minutes you are a courteous stranger with a good ear, not a partner with a file.

1. In silence, about 5 minutes, each of you writes three questions a polite stranger could ask this person. Mix them: a memory of a year or room when they felt most like themselves; a habit a new friend would misread, and what that misreading gets wrong; a belief they rarely say in a group, asked so they can decline.
2. It qualifies only if it needs no shared history and cannot be answered in one word. Tear up anything worn out this month, and anything that is a flirt-test or a cross-examination.
3. Ask one at a time. One follow-up may ask to see the answer more clearly. It may not corner it. A declined question is a complete answer. Then swap.

Name one thing you had not known how to ask. Leave the rest on the paper.

Either of you may pass the whole card. Passing is a finished visit.



C02 · KNOWING

The Life You've Never Told Me

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Life You've Never Told Me

One episode the relationship has not heard, told once, without a diagnosis.

1. Alone, about 5 minutes, jot four anchors, not a script. Place: where the bodies were. The turn: the moment the day changed, in one sentence. One formative person inside this episode. What still echoes in an ordinary week now.
2. Decide who tells first. Set 8 to 10 minutes. The teller speaks or reads without interruption.
3. The listener keeps the episode in view. Do not correct a date, diagnose a family, or rush to why the teller is this way. If a matching story rises, put a hand on the table or on your own knee and leave it there until the timer is yours.
4. Swap with the same clock. A matching story after both turns is optional.

The listener says one concrete detail they are keeping, not a moral. The teller may correct that detail.

If the episode is too live tonight, say so and choose another, or pass the card.



C03 · KNOWING

The Things Nobody Thinks to Ask

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Things Nobody Thinks to Ask

Three questions you have never asked this person. Leave favorite colors in the other room.

1. Each of you writes three questions you have never asked. Spread them across more than one kind: belief, habit, memory, preference, private thought. You do not have to hit all five kinds tonight.
2. Examples you may discard: a money rule absorbed before you could argue with it; what your hands do in the first minute you are alone in a kitchen; a hallway that still belongs to a version of you this relationship has not met; the texture of quiet you want after a loud day.
3. Ask one. The answer can be short. One curious follow-up is allowed. Advice is not.
4. Decline any question. Then swap until each written question has been asked or retired.

Each of you names the question you are glad existed, even if you declined it.

A declined question is complete. Passing the card is complete.



C04 · KNOWING

The Museum of Me

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Museum of Me

You curate four pieces of a life. Your partner is a visitor, not a critic.

1. Each curator prepares four exhibits. Every label has three lines: what it is, which stretch of life it holds, and why it is in the collection. A mug, a person, a song, or a missed train can be an exhibit.
2. If all four are achievements, replace one with something ordinary, odd, or unfinished.
3. The curator speaks the labels in their own order. After each exhibit the visitor may ask one question that asks to see the piece more clearly. A question that replaces the piece with the visitor's theory does not count. Ask another, or ask none.
4. Then the visitor becomes the curator.

The visitor names the exhibit they will remember, in the curator's words, and the curator may correct the label.

Any exhibit may stay in storage. Say "not on view" and continue.



C05 · KNOWING

The Opinion I Changed

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Opinion I Changed

How you actually change your mind, told without a trophy.

1. Choose who goes first by appetite, not by the more impressive conversion. Set about 8 minutes.
2. The teller speaks three beats in order. The old sentence. What shifted it. How they tend to change.
3. The listener does not prosecute the current view and does not applaud a flattering conversion. They ask only: "What was the hardest part to let go?"
4. After the answer, the listener reflects the growth line in one sentence. The teller corrects it if needed. That correction is the listening. Then swap, with the same time.

If the reflection was fair, the teller says so in a few words. Stop there.

If you have no change you want to tell, pass. Passing is a complete card.